

Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS**

skill development programmes has shifted from curriculum and delivery to financing. Over the last decade, we have learnt five design principles that attract new financing—learning by doing, learning while earning, learning with qualification modularity, learning with flexible delivery and learning with signalling value. The central government is important, but state governments must take the lead in innovation.

Create a national open compliance grid: India's revolution in payments, identity and vaccination certificates enabled by DPI (Digital Public Infrastructure) has not been replicated in government plumbing. We must replicate this open and stacked architecture by creating a non-profit national compliance corporation that will use a unique enterprise number to house the API/ interface layer for all employer filings, compliance and workflows and enable private sector innovation in straight-through processing for employers.

One labour code: It is impossible for employers to comply with all of India's labour laws without violating some of them. Increasing our manufacturing jobs needs a single labour code as a powerful signal of our policy intent to protect employees while creating more formal employers.

NEP acceleration: India's many education policy documents—the 1948 Radhakrishnan report, the 1968 Kothari Committee report and the 1986 National Education policy—were useful but incomplete. NEP 2020 finally gives us a roadmap that breaks down the barriers between education and employability, pushes holistic learning, grants *poorna swaraj* (complete independence) to universities, expands apprenticeships, and much else. Unfortunately, the NEP's glide path for implementation was 15 years for consensus-building. But the world of work and education are changing fast and we should bring down the implementation of this roadmap to five years.

The Chinese Communist party's third plenum recently decided to seek "high quality" rather than "high speed" growth. China's reliance on high debt, high leverage and enormous levels of fixed investment in infrastructure has banged into natural limits unfamiliar to democracies like India. India may not have mass prosperity but we have impressive islands of excellence—exporting more software than Saudi Arabia did oil in 2021, getting $120 billion in remittances from 17 million Indians overseas and being the world's pharmacy. The arrogance of the Avadi Resolution of 1955 sabotaged mass prosperity. Righting this wrong—our new tryst with destiny—is complementing our political independence with economic freedom. ■

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